

National Coverage Determination (NCD)

Transcutaneous Electrical Nerve Stimulation (TENS) for Acute Post-Operative Pain

10.2

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Tracking Information

Publication Number

100-3

Manual Section Number

10.2

Manual Section Title

Transcutaneous Electrical Nerve Stimulation (TENS) for Acute Post-Operative Pain

Version Number

2

Effective Date of this Version

06/08/2012

Implementation Date

01/07/2013

Description Information

Benefit Category

Incident to a physician's professional Service

Inpatient Hospital Services

Outpatient Hospital Services Incident to a Physician's Service

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

The use of transcutaneous electrical nerve stimulation (TENS) for the relief of acute post-operative pain is covered under Medicare. TENS may be covered whether used as an adjunct to the use of drugs, or as an alternative to drugs, in the treatment of acute pain resulting from surgery.

The TENS devices, whether durable or disposable, may be used in furnishing this service. When used for the purpose of treating acute post-operative pain, TENS devices are considered supplies. As such they may be hospital supplies furnished inpatients covered under Part A, or supplies incident to a physician's service when furnished in connection with surgery done on an outpatient basis, and covered under Part B.

It is expected that TENS, when used for acute post-operative pain, will be necessary for relatively short periods of time, usually 30 days or less. In cases when TENS is used for longer periods, contractors should attempt to ascertain whether TENS is no longer being used for acute pain but rather for chronic pain, in which case the TENS device may be covered as durable medical equipment as described in [§160.27](#).

Cross Reference

[Medicare Benefit Policy Manual](#), Chapter 1 "Inpatient Hospital Services," §40; [Medicare Benefit Policy Manual](#), Chapter 2 "Hospital Services Covered Under Part B," §§20, 20.4, and 80; [Medicare Benefit Policy Manual](#), Chapter 15, "Covered Medical and other Health Services, §110."

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

149

Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/Regulations-and-Guidance/Guidance/Transmittals/Downloads/R149NCD.pdf>

Revision History

11/2012 - (Rev.149, Issued: 11-30-12, Effective: 06-08-12, Implementation: 01-07-13)

07/1995 - Determined that TENS covered under durable medical equipment benefit rather than prosthetic device benefit. Effective date 08/07/1995. (TN 78)

National Coverage Analyses (NCAs)

This NCD has been or is currently being reviewed under the National Coverage Determination process. The following are existing associations with NCAs, from the National Coverage Analyses database.

- [Original Consideration for Transcutaneous Electrical Nerve Stimulation for Chronic Low Back Pain \(CAG-00429N\)](#) 

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Transcutaneous Electrical Nerve Stimulation (TENS) for Acute Post-Operative Pain	2	06/08/2012 - N/A	You are here
Transcutaneous Electrical Nerve Stimulation (TENS) for Acute Post-Operative Pain	1	08/07/1995 - 06/08/2012	View